

other states in the region, so that by 221 BCE all seven states were unified under his rule. Disdaining the old title of king (*Wang*), he styled himself as emperor (*Huangdi*). Since he was the first (*Shi*) emperor of the Qin dynasty, he was known as Qin Shi Huang.

The governing philosophy of the Qin state had been legalism: strict centralization of power and severity in enforcing adherence to the law. The emperor now set about applying this philosophy throughout the whole of China, ruthlessly imposing cultural, linguistic, economic, and technological unity. All scripts except Xiaozhuan (small seal script) were banned. In addition, according to legend, the emperor gave orders for 400 Confucian scholars to be buried alive and all existing books to be burned; his reign was to mark a new “Year One” in the history and culture of China. He also introduced a host of economic reforms—there was to be a single, unified system of weights and measures, a uniform coinage, and even the gauge of cart tracks was standardized so that axle-widths could be the same across the empire.

The new order

The new social and political order of the empire reflected changes that had been underway since the Spring and Autumn Period. The feudal system was abolished, so the mass of peasantry now owed their allegiance to the state rather than feudal or clan lords. Over 100,000 noble families were relocated to the emperor’s capital city Xianyang (near Xi’an, in the Shaanxi province), and their arms were confiscated, melted down, and then cast into giant statues. During the Warring States Period, the pressure of incessant military competition had generally favored the emergence of more meritocratic avenues for advancement, thereby facilitating social mobility while undermining the importance of noble lineage. In the Qin dynasty, aristocratic rule was replaced with a centralized bureaucratic administration and the country was divided into 36 commanderies, which were administrative divisions controlled by appointed (not hereditary) governors. Censors, or inspectors, traveled the country to enforce adherence to Qin law.

The Qin dynasty also saw the emergence of a new scheme of social stratification, with society divided into four classes: gentlemen (*Shi*), peasants (*Nong*), and two new classes that had emerged during the Zhou dynasty—artisans (*Gong*) and merchants (*Shang*). The educated gentry would replace the nobility as the main source of state officials. The merchant class was officially the »



Qin Shi Huang

As First Emperor of China, Ying Zheng (later known as Qin Shi Huang, 260–210 BCE) was a truly pivotal figure in Chinese history, uniting the country and ushering in a period of imperial rule that lasted nearly 2,000 years. He was a brutal despot but was also innovative, dynamic, and energetic—reports claim that he needed just one hour’s sleep per night and he set himself a daily work quota, measured by the weight of papers that he needed to go through. He regularly walked the city streets in disguise to keep tabs on the populace, and he made five great tours of inspection of the empire. Highly paranoid and fearful of possible attempts on his life (he survived at least one assassination attempt), the emperor became obsessed with the quest for immortality, sponsoring expeditions to look for magic ingredients and mystics who could brew an elixir of life, to enable him to live forever. Ironically, his death at the age of 50 might well have been linked to his consumption of toxic mercury-based potions that he had taken to extend his life.